

Avoiding Redundancies

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- The best way to avoiding redundancy is to read your own writing slowly and carefully. For each sentence you read, ask yourself these questions:
 - Have I already said this somewhere earlier in my paper? If so, do I really need to say it again?
 - Do my readers really need to know this in order to understand my meaning? If you find yourself doubting whether something is necessary, the answer is probably no.
 - Could I rephrase this using fresh, new language? Is there a way to say the same thing in a different way?
- If possible, have someone else read your writing with the same questions in mind. Use this reader's feedback to revise your work for concision.

- Redundancy means superfluity or using words unnecessarily or using words for a second time.
- Eliminating redundancy is a good way to revise your writing for concision, or the ability to make your point in as few words as needed.
- Observe the redundancy in the following word pairs:
 - Evil villains
 - Dead corpses
 - Added bonus
 - Unexpected surprise
 - Hopeful optimism
- Aren't all villains evil? Aren't all corpses dead? Aren't all bonuses added? Aren't all surprises unexpected? Isn't all optimism hopeful?

- In each of these word pairs, the writer need not use both words to express his or her meaning; therefore, it is more effective to eliminate the adjective and let the noun serve on its own.

For example, read the following sentence:

At this point in time, it now becomes necessary for us to consider alternative possibilities for the purposes of our goals.

- This sentence is wordy and unclear primarily because it is redundant; there are several words that could be deleted without affecting the meaning of the sentence. For instance, *at this point of time* and *now* mean the same thing, so the writer could save space by just using *now*:

It now becomes necessary for us to consider alternative possibilities for the purposes of our goals.

- Next, why not simply write alternatives instead of alternative possibilities?
- It now becomes necessary for us to consider alternatives for the purposes of our goals.
- Next, what does for the purposes of our goals do for this sentence?
- Could it be eliminated from the sentence without changing the sentence's meaning? Aren't all alternatives considered for the purposes of one's goals?

It now becomes necessary for us to consider alternatives.

- Next, the writer could make the subject *we* in order to eliminate the need for *for* us. Similarly, *becomes necessary* could be replaced with *need*:

We now need to consider alternatives.

- By cleaning up redundancy, the writer has shortened this sentence from 21 words to just six words, all without changing the meaning of the sentence. The new sentence is clearer and easier to read.
- How do you tell which words are necessary, and which words are not? Search your writing sentence by sentence for words that are similar to each other. See the example below;

Matt had to work late to correct an unintentional mistake made on his report, which was due the next day.

- In this sentence, the words “unintentional” and “mistake” imply the same thing: an action done in error.
- “Mistake” means “error,” and “unintentional” is used to describe something done by mistake, so only one of the words is needed for clarity.

- A more concise version of the sentence would read:

Matt had to work late to correct a mistake on his report due the next day.

Avoid Expletives:

- Expletives are words that serve a grammatical function in a sentence but have no meaning. The most common expletives are *it is*, *there is*, *there are*, and related phrases.

Weak: *There is* no alternative for us except to withdraw the product.

Strong: We have no alternative except to withdraw the product.

Weak: *It is* hoped that testing the evaluation copies will help us make a decision.

Strong: We hope that testing the evaluation copies will help us make a decision.

Avoid Nominalized Verbs/Nominalization:

- Nominalized verbs are verbs that have been changed into nouns then coupled with weaker verbs. To avoid nominalizations, you can use verbs or adjectives instead of nouns, and avoid phrases such as "the process of", "the result of", or "the effect of".

Weak: Each *preparation* of the solution is done twice.

Strong: Each solution is prepared twice.

Weak: *Consideration* should be given to an *acquisition* of the properties.

Strong: We should consider acquiring the properties.

Weak: The implementation of the solution was successful.

Strong: The solution worked.

Avoid Fillers:

- In our writing, we sometimes use fillers, many of which are more suited to speech. Most of these fillers are meaningless in writing. Some examples of fillers are *basically, kind of, certain, rather, essentially, sort of*. These words simply “*bloat*” your paper.

Bloated: *I think that, basically, the board felt sort of betrayed, in a sense, by the kind of behavior the president displayed.*

Better: *The board felt betrayed by the president’s behavior.*

- Other fillers include redundant expressions, such as *collaborate together, past history, end result, any and all, still remain, completely eliminate, very unique*. Say what you mean once.

Redundant: This project would not have succeeded if not for the *hard work and considerable effort* of *each and every one* of the auditors.

Better: *This project would not have succeeded if not for the hard work of every one of the auditors.*

Avoid Unnecessary Prepositional Phrases:

- A prepositional phrase consists of a preposition followed by a noun or a noun equivalent, such as *in the summary, on the engine, under the heading*. Unnecessary prepositional phrases, often used with abstract nouns and nominalizations, can make your writing long and boring.

Long: The increase *in* the number *of* students enrolled *in* the materials- engineering program *at* Lehigh University is suggestive *of* the regard *in* which that program is held *by* the university's new students.

Shorter: The growth of Lehigh University's materials-engineering program suggests that the university's new students consider it a good program.

Avoid Wordy Phrases:

- Wordy phrases also make writing long and boring. For example, many people write *on a daily basis* instead of *daily*. The longer sentence may sound more important, but *daily* says the same thing more concisely.

Wordy: I am of the opinion that, in regard to profit achievement, the statistics pertaining to this month will appear to indicate an upward tendency.

Concise: I think that this month's statistics will show an increase in profits.



Thank You!